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CHAPTER ONE

THE EYES HAVE IT

Votive Statuary, Gilgamesh's Axe, and Cathected Viewing in the Ancient Near East

IRENE J. WINTER

For H.B.:
zi-ša$_3$-gal$_2$-la šu-dagal-du$_{11}$-ga

The enlarged, staring eyes of Mesopotamian votive statues (Figs. 2–4) have often been remarked upon as a characteristic stylistic feature, only occasionally with the proposition that their function must have been to denote attentiveness toward the presumed object of their gaze.[1] Yet it is now known that these statues were placed in shrines either seated within their own chapels or standing in direct visual contact with the resident deity.[2] The effect is frequently enhanced by inlay: shell for the white of the eye, lapis lazuli or bitumen for the pupil. The panoply of assembled statues from the Square Temple at Tell Asmar in the third millennium B.C.E., as photographed for the University of Chicago Diyala Expedition in the 1930s, gives an almost eerie sense of absolute and focused attention (Fig. 4).[3] In later periods, inscribed banded agate "eye-stones" actually bear the name of, and occasionally messages of dedication by, the donor that are literally "beamed" at the deity.[4] All of this suggests a tradition in which visual attention is stressed, a complement to the verbal attention that is contained in letter-prayers, and even in instructions given to the statues themselves to "speak" to the deity on behalf of the devotee.[5]

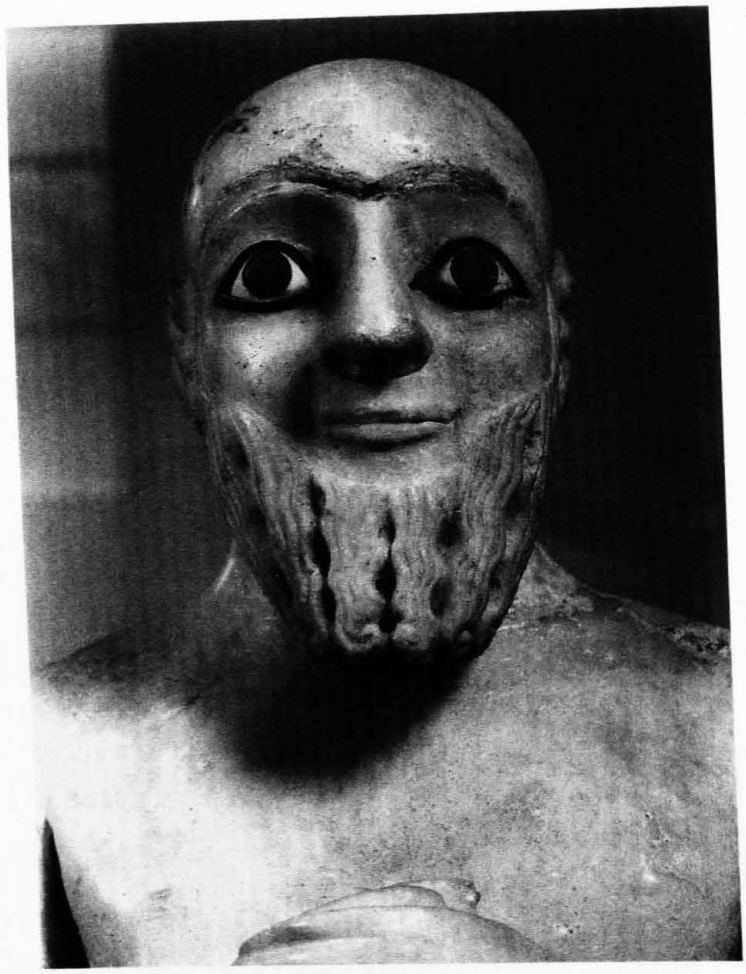
I should like to thank the editor, Robert Nelson, for the opportunity to participate in the present volume, since the issues with which I have been concerned mesh so well with those that governed his original symposium in Los Angeles. I would also like to thank Benjamin Studevent-Hickman and Jülide Aker for close readings of an earlier version of the manuscript; and Froma Zeitlin for a series of wonderfully stimulating conversations, plus a number of sources otherwise not known to me. I am deeply indebted to the work of Thorkild Jacobsen, with whom many of these questions were discussed before his death. Finally, several of the observations contained in the present study, especially those related to Sumerian terms for sight and their logographic writing, owe their present form to rich exchanges with Hermann Behrens. That he did not live to receive the fruit of those exchanges has been, and will remain, a source of great sadness.

Less studied has been the power of the visual experience articulated in ancient Mesopotamian texts, where the references are not merely implicitly suggested but explictly acknowledged. Indeed, exhortations to view an extraordinary phenomenon often precede description, as if the intended audience were expected to *see and experience* the object of the gaze as distinct from merely processing descriptive information intellectually. Thus, the standard Neo-Assyrian version of the Gilgamesh epic opens with instructions concerning the sacred Eanna Temple precinct in Uruk: "Look at its wall that gleams like copper(?); inspect its inner wall, the likes of which no one can equal!" Then the poem further instructs: "Go up on the (city-) wall of Uruk and walk around; examine its foundation, inspect its brickwork!" – the implicit assumption being that the ensuing inspection will be sufficient to assure for the city-state of the young ruler its rightful place as the preeminent cultural center of its time.[6]

The direct relationship between exhortation and *ekphrasis* immediately calls to mind classical Greek constructions, as in Euripides' *Ion,* where the chorus, comprised of citizens of Athens, first views, then describes the temple of Apollo at Delphi. A series of exhortations to look alternate with descriptions of specific aspects of the sculptural program supposedly before them, as the iconographic program is revealed.[7] Nor does this event stand alone; rather, as demonstrated by Froma Zeitlin, it is part of an identifiable genre in which sightseers come to a temple precinct or another public place and feast their eyes upon an architectural or artifactual phenomenon.[8]

Vision and visuality have been extensively studied in connection with Greek sources, ranging from specific cases, such as the erotic transfer from beloved to representation in the *Alcestis,*[9] to the broader "phenomenology of sight".[10] That this emphasis, both cultural and scholarly, should be evident in the classical tradition will surprise no one; that parallel concepts should have been richly developed in ancient Mesopotamia, from Sumerian through Neo-Babylonian times, is, if not less expected, certainly less well known, and to date has not been explicitly studied. Yet the literary exhortations found in the Gilgamesh epic, no less than those of the *Ion,* serve as rhetorical invitations to share experience through a common exhortation to view. They beg the question of variable responses, presuming the mutuality of sensory response in the guise of a request to the audience to see what the author has determined should be seen. In royal inscriptions, which constitute the largest class of relevant documents in the Mesopotamian corpus, this presumption takes on the role of a constitutive statement. When a palace is built, for example, and stated to be "without equal," it becomes so precisely because it has been proclaimed by royal authority to be so.

More rarely, particularly in poetic literature, we are given a glimpse of visual experience through direct speech. In an early-second-millennium B.C.E. fragment of the Gilgamesh epic dated to the Old Babylonian period, for example, we are able to step outside of the official corpus of often-formulaic royal inscriptions. Using the literary device of direct speech, Gilgamesh relates a dream to his mother, describing his



2. Detail, Statue of Ibih-il, found at Mari. Early Dynastic III Period, ca. 2500 B.C.E. (Photo M. Chuzeville, courtesy Département des antiquités orientales, Musée du Louvre, Paris)

vision of an artifact, an axe of unusual appearance. He goes on to report: *āmuršuma ahtadu anāku arāmšuma kīma aššatim,* "I saw it, and I felt (such) joy; I loved it as (one would) a woman."[11] The hero then fell to caressing the axe, declaring it his brother (i.e., his trusted companion). Now, for purposes of the epic narrative, the dream is interpreted as a foreshadowing of the coming of Enkidu, the semi-wild man of the steppe who will become a companion to him; but what is important for our purposes is the coupling of the visual experience with such a strong emotional cathexion to the object.

It would be a truism to insist that a given aesthetic object can only be experienced and its impact appreciated by the acts of looking and seeing, were it not for the fact that Mesopotamian tradition reinforces the act, not merely the object.[12] That there was a well-developed vocabulary for seeing and looking in both Sumerian and Akkadian, the languages of ancient Mesopotamia, needs no argument. A plethora of verbs (Sumerian **igi . . . du$_8$, igi . . . la$_2$, igi . . . bar, igi . . . gal$_2$;** Akkadian *amāru, barû, dagālu, hâṭu, naṭālu, palāsu [naplusu]*) cover as many nuanced aspects as one could find in modern English: to see, behold (by eye hold!); to regard, look at, observe, inspect; to survey, explore, examine; to stare.[13] Parallel to this developed vocabulary is the number of occasions in Mesopotamian literary and historical texts in which the act of looking is described, or visual inspection is invited. These occurrences range from love poetry and heroic epics, in which the regard of the beloved or the display of the hero are woven into evaluative passages, to building accounts in which the finished product is presented to an intended audience.

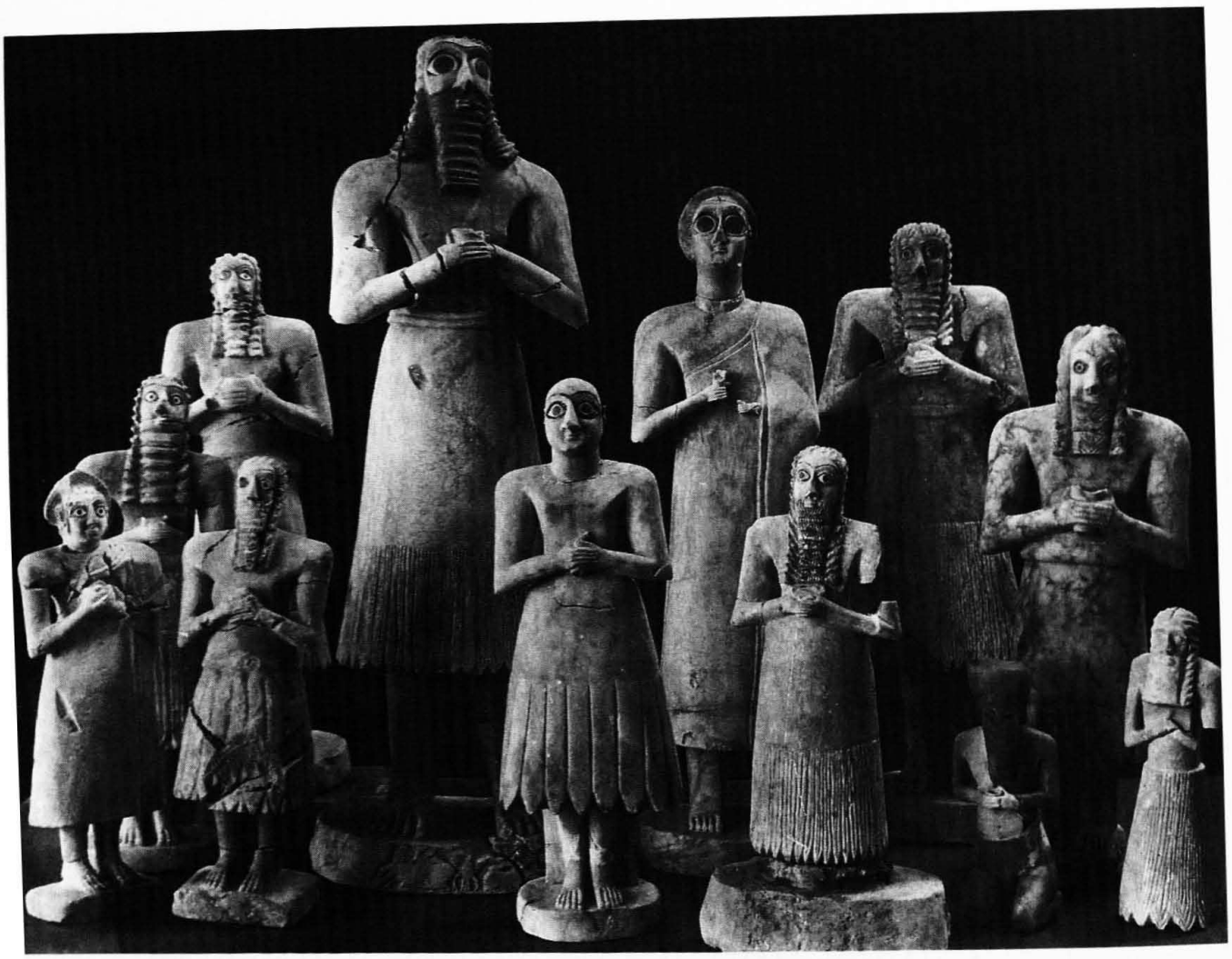
The most frequent responses to an envisioned object occur in association with human love or affection, the object then being the beloved – sexual partner or companion. One bilingual text describes a well-endowed young man as "one who is fitting (i.e, satisfying) to look at" (Sum. **igi.bar he$_2$.du$_7$** = Akk. *ša ana naplusi asmu*).[14]

In the Neo-Assyrian version of the Gilgamesh epic, when Gilgamesh is described to Enkidu before the two actually meet, Enkidu first is invited to "see him, look into his face" *(amur šâšu uṭul pānišu)*.[15] Only then does the passage go on to describe the hero. In the following passage, Gilgamesh is called a "well-formed youth, bearing vitality; adorned with allure (is) his whole body" *(elṭūta bani balta iši/zu'una kuzba kalu zumrišu)*.[16] The poetics of alliteration call for axial symmetry of each line based upon initial word sounds (vowel:b:b:vowel in the first line, z:k:k:z in the second), which delivers a sort of litany of attributes when spoken aloud; but even in English, one gets a strong mental image once we have been instructed, through Enkidu, to see the heroic figure.

3. Detail, Statue of Gudea, ruler of Lagash, found at Tello. Neo-Sumerian Period, ca. 2110 B.C.E. (Photo by Jill Casid, reproduced courtesy Département des antiquités orientales, Musée du Louvre, Paris)

Indeed, this verbal description conforms most closely with the rendering of the well-formed body of the Akkadian ruler Naram-Sin (ca. 2250 B.C.E.) on his stele found at Susa (Fig. 5), such that it has been suggested that the relationship is not accidental.[17] Nor are the descriptions of Gilgamesh and his axe the only instances of picturing vision in the epic. In the Old Babylonian version cited above in the episode with the axe, once Gilgamesh has found his companion, he is made to say in direct speech: *anaṭṭalka Enkidu kīma ilim tabašši,* "I look at you, Enkidu, (and) you are like a god."[18] In other words, in both cases, where description could have sufficed (Gilgamesh is well formed; Enkidu is like a god), the literary devices of exhortation or firsthand report are employed in such a way as to focus upon the act of viewing that underlies the visual assessment.

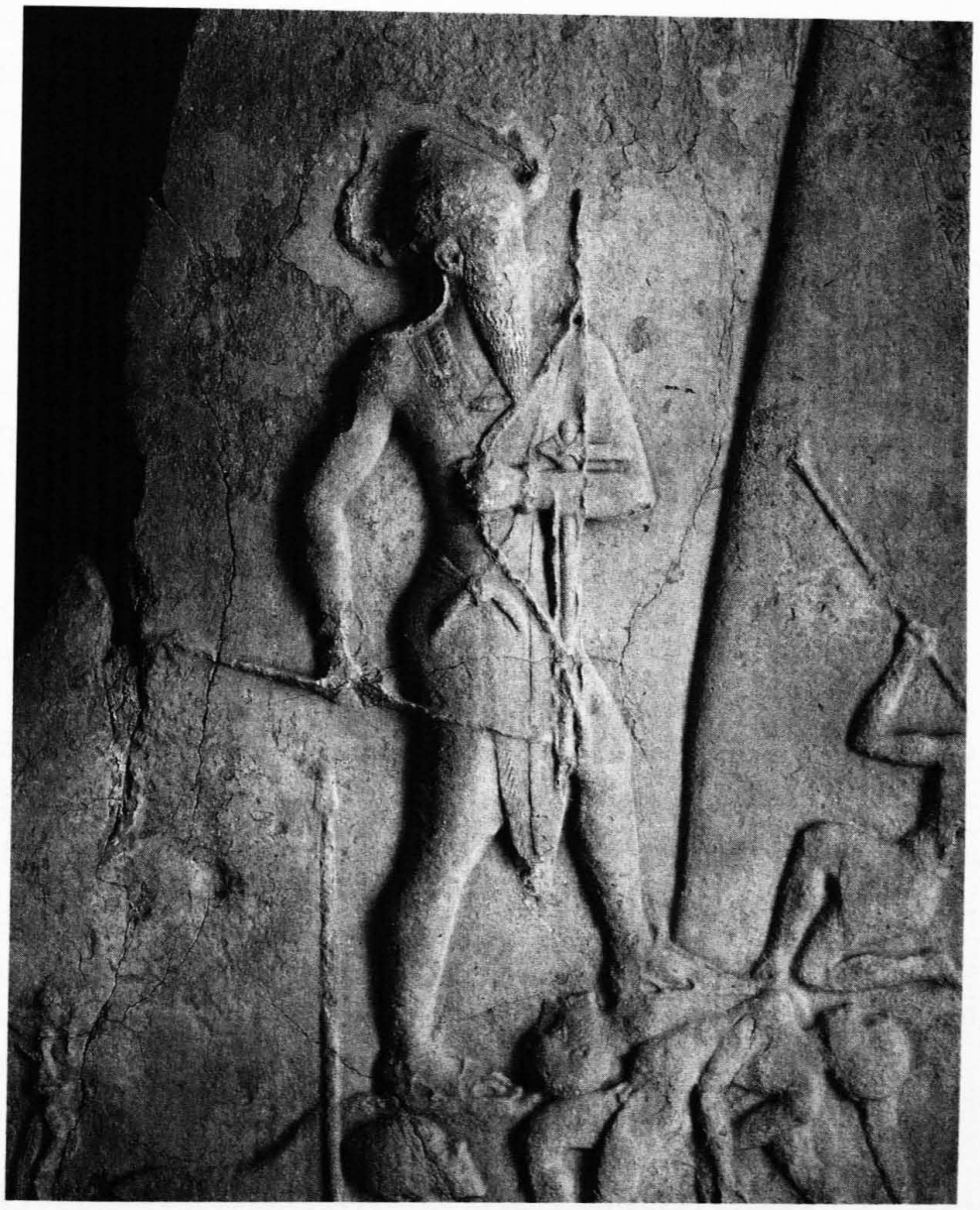
In addition to the positive view *of* the beloved, the lover's regard is itself described positively, as in an example of Sumerian love poetry in which the lover says to his sister/beloved: **igi-za igi du$_8$-ru-na-bi ma-dug$_3$,** "the gaze of your eye/your regard is pleasing to me."[19] The positive regard of gods or kings, described in terms of glowing or shining (not unlike the English "beaming" at someone), is also seen as



4. Votive statues from the Square Temple, Tell Asmar. Early Dynastic Periods II and III, ca. 2750–2400 B.C.E. (Photo courtesy The Oriental Institute, University of Chicago)

a mark of favor: *ina būnīšunu namrūtim l[ū i]ppalsūnim,* "with their shining faces, truly they looked at me"; and rulers are flattered by courtiers who speak of their desire to enter before the king "in order to see his gracious face," *ana dagāli pānišu damqūta.*[20] Verbs of seeing can also be stressed, so that individuals are invited to stare/look hard at, not merely see, particular phenomena, as in one twelfth-century bilingual Babylonian text concerning the image of a god: *ibtarrâ niš māti lānšu elâ,* "[T]he people of the land stared at his [i.e., the deity's] tall/lofty figure."[21] Thus, the relationship between being on view and appreciative visual assessment is well established with respect to persons and imputed to deities in the literature, and indeed, the conclusion of the line of the Babylonian text just cited is that, the people once having seen the god's lofty (and fitting, and majestic, and bright) image, *they all paid attention to him* – that is, they focused upon the god himself, as well as cathecting to the image. The aesthetic aspects of that concentration of emotional energy are demonstrated through the qualities of form and stature selected for and described in conjunction with favorable viewing; the importance of visual experience is indicated through being acknowledged as the necessary pathway to engagement.

This emphasis on vision and the subsequent process of assessment through



5. Detail, Stele of Naram-Sin, found at Susa. Akkadian Period, ca. 2250 B.C.E. (Photo courtesy Département des antiquités orientales, Musée du Louvre, Paris)

focused viewing can also be demonstrated with respect to works such as temples, palaces, and precious objects. The Old Babylonian Gilgamesh fragment cited clearly illustrates the degree to which visual affect was acknowledged in conjunction with inanimate objects, when the hero's dream-axe is described as having elicited such a powerful response. Since the majority of other textual references come from the official corpus of royal documents, with their own propagandistic agendas, the visual attributes recorded for royal undertakings are generally given positive value, and in such cases, the response to the specific visual stimulus is expected to be admiring. Nevertheless, even through these carefully managed texts, it is possible to glean a sense of the importance of seeing, and thereby the importance of audience, for works we would call "art," as well as for animate objects of desire.

Often the gods are the selected audience, particularly in royal inscriptions where the building of temples is recorded. When the Middle Assyrian ruler Shalmaneser I

(1274–1245 B.C.E.) rebuilds the Assur temple after the destruction of an earlier one by fire and the god is brought in to take up residence in the new temple, the ruler describes his hope that his work will bring satisfaction in terms of the god's first seeing and then being pleased with his new abode: *epšēti nimurti E_2 šâtu līmurma lihdâ,* "[M]ay he (the god Assur) see the bright/shining works of that temple and rejoice."[22] The Neo-Assyrian ruler Esarhaddon (680–669 B.C.E.) also consistently concludes his temple-building accounts with the hope that the deity involved may "look joyously" upon the king's work.[23] In one of the more complete accounts, Esarhaddon first records the installation of the god Assur in his temple, the placement of other deities and various animal attributes around him, and the establishment of regular cult offerings. Then the god's reaction is provided, not as an aspiration but as a matter of record: *epšētia damqāte kēniš ippalisma ēliṣ libbašu,* "When he (Assur) looked steadfastly upon my good works, his heart rejoiced."[24]

Deities are not the only audience whose gaze is invoked. On the colossal gateway lion from the Sharrat Niphi temple in Nimrud, Assurnasirpal II (883–859 B.C.E.) records that he built the temple "for the eternal regard of rulers and princes," *ana nan[mar m]alkī.MEŠ u_3 NUN.MEŠ ša dārâte ēpuš,* and the same construction is used on blocks from the king's Northwest Palace at Nimrud.[25] It may well be the case that the public location of the lion inscription and the palace orthostats accounts for the particular audience addressed – those rulers who will enter the temple or palace in later years as equals and be in a position to restore them, as expressed explicitly toward the end of the Sharrat Niphi inscription.[26] However, in the Northwest Palace inscription, no specific instructions for repairs and maintenance in the future follow; rather, after being invited to gaze, the future ruler is simply told that the king made the palace fitting and splendid "for eternity," *ana dārâte,* installing colossal beasts of limestone and alabaster in its doorways.[27] What these last citations provide is both the expansion of the audience beyond the gods to future generations of rulers, and also the juxtaposition of spectacular works to the assertion that the palace has been built to be seen for eternity.

A text of the Neo-Babylonian ruler Nebuchadnezzar II (604–562 B.C.E.) goes even further, linking the viewing of luxurious appointments with admiration and stating its intended audience to be all peoples, not merely kings and princes: *bīta šâtim ana tabrâti ušēpišma ana daqālim kiššat nišē lulê ušmalīša,* "I had that temple built for admiration, (and) for the viewing/regard of all the people I filled it with delight(s)."[28] We shall return to the particular goal of provoking admiration, but for the present, the linkage of viewing, spectacle (in this case, the temple), and response is clearly established, as is the range of audience, from god, to future rulers, to "the people."

The exhortation to view works that by our definition would be included in the category of "art," and/or the aspiration to have such works viewed (and admired), extends to goods as well as buildings, and one can find a similar range of audiences invoked. In a Neo-Babylonian text of Nabonidus (555–539 B.C.E.), for example, the god Shamash is enjoined to "look joyously upon the precious products of the

king's hands, his auspicious works," *lipitti qātīa šūquru epšētīia damqāta . . . ḫadīš naplisamma,* and amongst these, the "royal image" is specifically mentioned.[29] In other words, the gods are specifically invited to look upon works in which there has been artistic investment and respond joyfully, that is, favorably.

In a text of Assurnasirpal I (1049–1030 B.C.E.), an ornate bed made for the inner chamber of the temple of the goddess Ishtar is elaborately described. The king tells us that the bed has been made of *taskarinnu*-wood (boxwood?) and gold, adorned with precious stones, and as a result, it shines "like the rays of the sun(god)." He then closes with the assessment: "for viewing it is suited," *an[a n]aṭāli asmat,* a construction not unlike that used for the well-formed youth *ša ana naplusi asmu,* one who is "suited to being looked at," that is, worth seeing.[30] In a Neo-Babylonian text some 500 years later, Nebuchadnezzar II also speaks of having deposited within a temple "everything that is (worthy of) being looked at": *mimma ša innaṭṭalu.*[31] In neither of these texts is the audience who will do the looking specified. Rather, it is the fact of being see-worthy that is emphasized, as if this in itself were a sufficient statement of the work's impact and value. The Assurnasirpal I text, being the more complete, actually provides us with the entire sequence: from construction through completion to response. First, the act of making the bed and its decoration is given attention; then, once completed, the bed shines like the sun, as a positive attribute; and finally, as such, it is worthy of regard.

Similarly, in a text of Shalmaneser III of Assyria (858–824 B.C.E.), the king records a statue *ša epšētušu ana daḡāli lullâ šūturū bunnanûšu,* "whose workmanship is pleasurable to behold, whose appearance is extraordinary."[32] Here, too, issues of facture (its workmanship) and representation (its extraordinary appearance) are articulated, and both are linked to viewing. But perhaps even more important: If through a combination of workmanship and visual attributes value is achieved, it is also the case that *through seeing, value is perceived.*

The Shalmaneser text further adds the emotional response of pleasure that comes as a result of seeing something satisfying. Surely, here, we come close to developed Western and South Asian notions of aesthetics as engaging sensory delight, not merely intellection. This is further attested in instances where the Assyrian kings project divine response to their acts of pious patronage. For the gods in question, it is quite explicit that seeing is the means by which satisfaction is to be ascertained. In one text, for example, Esarhaddon projects a goddess's response upon seeing his restoration work in Babylonia, when he describes the goddess Nanâ as "joyous in her regard (of) that work," *šipir šâšu ᵈNanâ hadīš ina naplusiša.*[33] The same mechanism is articulated as Esarhaddon describes his rebuilding of the temple of the goddess Gula; however, there he expresses the hope that "she may then look joyfully upon this work."[34] Similarly, his son, Assurbanipal (668–627 B.C.E.) requests the goddess Ninmah to "look joyfully upon my auspicious works," *epšētia damqāti hadīš lippalis.*[35]

This formulation goes back at least into the second millennium B.C.E., as is evident from the statement of Shalmaneser I that concludes his description of the

rebuilding of the Assur temple, earlier destroyed by fire. The full passage reads: "When Assur, the lord, enters that temple and joyfully takes his place on the lofty dais, may he see the shining workmanship of that temple and rejoice," *enūma ᵈAššur EN ana E_2 šâtu ibâ'uma $BARA_2$-šu ṣīra ḫadīš irammû epšēti nimruti E_2 šâtu līmurma liḫdâ.*[36]

As this study represents an initial attempt to lay out the sources for the Mesopotamian visual experience, I have selected from a broad range of texts, both chronological and typological. Future research may demonstrate different attitudes toward the nature of vision and viewing, depending upon whether sources tend to be so-called historical (i.e., royal) texts or literary texts, such as epics and love poetry. One could argue that the appreciative response desired in royal texts is largely rhetorical. Indeed, there are instances when the intended quid pro quo is made quite explicit, as when Esarhaddon expresses the hope that when the goddess Nanâ is "joyous in her viewing" of the restoration work he has done on her cult sanctuary, *ḫadīš ina naplusiša,* she might put in a good word for him before the god Nabû.[37] On another occasion, he addresses the same goddess directly, saying: "if/when you are joyous in your dwelling," *ḫadiš ina ašābiki,* and then proceeds to list what benefits might come to him – that she might speak well of him, establish a good fate for him, and so forth.[38] Nevertheless, the status accorded the gaze of the divine beneficiary, as the necessary act of perception prior to affirmation and benevolent patronage, reinforces the power of visual cathexion in Mesopotamian tradition.

Yet another type of visual response is consistently recorded: that of "the people" to a major work. Whereas the reaction of "joy" is ascribed to gods and rulers, who are the direct beneficiaries of these works, which by our definition we call "art," lower-echelon viewers are said, rather, to respond with "admiration" and, on occasion, with "awe" (Sum. **u_6-di** and **ni_2-me-gar;** Akk. *tabrītu* and *qâlu*). In a Sumerian text recording the dedication of a cultic vessel on behalf of Rim-Sin of Larsa (ca. 1822–1763 B.C.E.), for example, the sacred gate of the great courtyard of a temple to Inanna is called the "place of ad+miration of the land," **ki-u_6-di-kalam-ma-ka.**[39]

I have broken the word *admiration* apart in the last translation in order to conform to its Latin prefix-plus-root, because it preserves exactly the relationship of viewing/seeing *(mirāre)* plus enhancement *(ad-)* which, when joined together, signify the same intensified sensory activity as does the Sumerian **u_6-di** and its Akkadian equivalent, *tabrītu* (to be discussed) – that is, *augmented viewing leading to positive response.* On its own, the cuneiform sign for **u_6** includes the ideographic sign for eye, **igi.** As a word, the Sumerian **u_6** has lexical equivalents to the Akkadian verbs of seeing, *barû, naṭālu* and *naplusu.*[40] Indeed, Thorkild Jacobsen has shown that the base meaning of **u_6** is the act of looking, and the verbal construction **u_6-e** or **u_6-di** is precisely the imperfective (i.e., ongoing) act of looking; so that the actual denotation of the **u_6-di**-response, that of "ad+miration," is predicated precisely upon continued looking.[41]

The Sumerian term **u_6-di** has often been translated by modern scholars as "won-

der," "marvel," "astonishment," thereby corresponding well to the Greek *thauma idesthai,* that "amazed stupor produced by seeing," or "looking in wonder and astonishment," so well documented in classical sources.[42] I believe the Sumerian does suggest all of these things in the lexicon of experience, and for a poetic translation, a single word like "wonder" would render the Sumerian (or Akkadian) well. But I would argue that for purposes of cultural analysis, only the more literal "ad+miration" captures the relationship between the visual *spectacle* and the *spectator's response* that is primary in the Sumerian and subsequent Akkadian/Neo-Assyrian usage.

It seems not irrelevant, therefore, that the components making up the Sumerian sign **u$_6$** are precisely those for eye, **igi** (as noted) and house, **e$_2$**. Although one greets most psychophilology with justified scepticism, in the present case the resultant ideogram, eye+house, seems to picture exactly the spectatorial role here being described, and physically articulate the visual underpinning of the reaction: ad+miration.

Deities and rulers can on occasion also evoke this response. The goddess Inanna, in a late third millennium hymn, is called **nin u$_6$-di-kalam-ma,** "lady, [object of] admiration of the land."[43] Shulgi of Ur (2094–2047 B.C.E.) is described in a royal hymn as **su$_6$-za-gin$_3$ gaba-ku$_3$-ga u$_6$-di,** "(king with a) dark lustrous beard, a pure/shining breast, a sight (to behold)," and implicitly, therefore, admirable, a wonder, a marvel.[44] And later on in the same hymn, the king is addressed directly: **mes-zi kurun$_3$-na-gun$_3$-a-gim u$_6$-di-du$_{10}$-ga-me-en$_3$,** "like a true **mes**-tree, sparkling with irridescent fruits, you are a sweet sight."[45]

The description of Shulgi is not unlike that given for Dumuzi, consort of the goddess Inanna, in one of the Sumerian temple hymns, probably of the same period: once again, "he of the pure/shining breast, a sight [to behold]," **u$_6$-di.**[46] Sjöberg, in his edition of the hymns, has translated the phrase "marvelous to behold," and indeed in context, this translation serves the sense quite well. In others of the temple hymns, the temples themselves, not their deities, are referred to in the same terms. The temple of Inanna in Kullaba is said to be **u$_6$-di ḫi-li gur$_3$-ru,** literally, "admirable, full of allure."[47] And the temple of Numušda in Kazallu is presented as **u$_6$-e gub-ba,** "set up (or established) for [unending] admiration."[48] Finally, in the hymn recording the building of the Ekur in Nippur by Shulgi's father, Ur-Namma, respondents are introduced. We are told specifically that the king established it (the temple) "for the admiration of the multitudes," **u$_6$-di-bi-še$_3$ un-sar$_2$-sar$_2$-ra-ba ši-im-ma-gub.**[49]

Nowhere is the sense of visual effect clearer than in the several references by Gudea of Lagash (ca. 2127–2110 B.C.E.) to his Eninnu temple, built for the god Ningirsu in the city of Girsu. Gudea's text represents the most eloquent account of a Sumerian temple thus far preserved. Statements of the temple's admirable qualities are repeated throughout Gudea's lengthy account of its building and consecration. In the first part, related to the building of the temple and known as Cylinder A, it is stated on more than one occasion that the temple was established to be admired,

u_6-di-de$_3$ ba-gub.[50] In the final summary description-cum-hymn to the temple at the end of that cylinder, we are told:

29: 14 **e_2-a ni$_2$-gal-bi**	The temple, its awesome radiance
15 **kalam-ma mu-ri**	was cast over the land;
16 **ka-tar-ra-bi**	its praise-song
17 **kur-re ba-ti . . .**	reached the mountains . . .
30: 11 **ḫi-li gur$_3$-a**	[the temple], bearing allure,
12 **u_6-di-de$_3$ gub-ba**	is established to be admired.

It is of particular interest that the closing point in the passage, which stands for the affect of the temple as a whole, is its nature as an object worthy of what we have been calling "ad+miration." Thus, the implication in modern language, which follows clearly from the context, is that once established, the result is nothing short of astonishing, marvelous, wondrous.

This is echoed further in Gudea's continuing account of his temple, known as Cylinder B, which describes the temple's consecration. After another laudatory description, we are told that not only the people but even the generic Anunna-gods "made their way to view (i.e., admire) it": **^{d}a-nun-na u_6-di-de$_3$ im-ma-šu$_4$-šu$_4$-ge-eš$_2$.**[51] That these undifferentiated, lower-level deities have journeyed to the temple and then respond positively urges us to understand that even if the underlying sense of the term **u_6-di** is "to see," the implication of that seeing is a positive loading of the experience, hence "ad+miration."

The sense of semantic loading is also clearly implied in the one negative case in the literature, the text known as the "Lamentation over Sumer and Ur," in which the temple of Nanna at Ur, the god's holy dwelling, described as once fragrant with cedar and decorated with gold, silver, and lapis lazuli, has been destroyed. Using the construction we have been considering, the text then states: "[T]he house/temple, the admiration of which was [once] so good, that admiration is (now) destroyed," **e_2 u_6-di-bi i$_3$-du$_{10}$-ga-ri u_6-di-bi ba-gul.**[52] Once again we see the same pattern of composition: After the affective attributes are presented, the summary statement relates to the visual response the temple had evoked. The context makes clear that the previous visually based admiration had been charged with the positive (**du$_{10}$**, "goodness," "sweetness"), and the loss is to be lamented. In the negative, we are able to see its opposite even more clearly – just how much the visual experience had previously been charged with positive affect.

Individual parts of temples, along with cult objects in which great care was invested, are also discussed in terms of their power to elicit admiration. The main courtyard of the Shamash temple in Larsa, the E.babbar, in a text of the ruler Sin-iddinam (1849–1843 B.C.E.), was called the "place of admiration of the land," **k[isa]l-maḫ eš$_3$ e_2-babbar-ra/ki-u_6-di-kalam-ma-ka.**[53] This is essentially the same phrase as that used for the courtyard of the E.me'urur temple in Larsa when a precious cult vessel for Inanna was set up there in honor of the ruler Rim-Sin.[54]

As for objects, a cultic **šakan**-vessel made by Ibbi-Sin of Ur (2028–2004 B.C.E.),

artfully formed and decorated with wild bulls and snakes, is celebrated as a work "the admiration of whose adornment is without end," **še-er-ga-an-du$_{11}$-ga-bi u$_6$-di nu-til-le-dam.**[55] A chariot for the god Enlil is further eulogized in direct speech by the ruler Išme-Dagan of Isin (1953–1935 B.C.E.): "[Y]ou are admirable [i.e., a thing of wonder] to behold, your appointments are outstanding," **nig$_2$-u$_6$-di gal$_2$-me-en giš.šu-kar$_2$-zu dalla maḫ im-e$_3$.**[56] These last citations make clear that not only buildings but also precious objects can elicit responses of admiration. In addition, the Išme-Dagan text makes a substantive out of the combination of **nig$_2$** (thing) and **u$_6$-di,** such that we have before us a "thing of admiration [or wonder]."

The Akkadian version of the same phenomenon is an exact lexical equivalent of the Sumerian, not infrequently actually written with Sumerian logograms.[57] Thus, for example, the Sumerian **u$_6$-di un-sar$_2$-ra** is the equivalent of Akkadian *tabrât kiššat nišē,* for the "admiration of all the people," with the Akkadian word *kiššatu* actually written with the Sumerian sign **sar$_2$** (and *nišē* often with the sign for **un,** "people"). What is more, the word *tabrītu* is a nominal formation from the verb *barû,* "to see," comparable to the visual component incorporated into the Sumerian logogram for **u$_6$.** Usage follows a similar pattern as well. Both Sennacherib (704–681 B.C.E.) and Esarhaddon of Assyria make frequent use of this formulation for their palaces inscriptions – Sennacherib also singling out his great gateway colossi as objects of admiration, if not astonishment.[58] Esarhaddon, in creating the palace of the crown prince for his son Assurbanipal, further amplifies the phrase by adding that it was *ana tabrât kiššat nišē.^{MES} lulê ušmalli,* "for the ad+miration [i.e., the admiring gaze] of all the people, I filled it with delight."[59] In a text cited earlier with respect to public viewing, Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon makes it even more explicit. By doubling the verbs related to sight, he emphasizes the visual experience even further: *bīta šâtim ana tabrâti ušēpišma ana dagālum kiššat nišē lulê ušmalliša,* "I had that temple built for ad+miration; for the regard of all the people, I filled it with delight(s)."[60] In other words, to provoke ad+miration is a motive in his doing, and to that end, he filled the temple with delight(s) so that it would be (perpetually) gazed at by all the people.

Nabopolassar (625–605 B.C.E.) adds another piece in the argument of intense admiration-stimulated-by-viewing, when, in speaking of his work on the temple of Marduk, he also includes the sense of "fitting" as a positive quality of the finished building: *ana tabrâtim lū ušāsimšu,* "for (the) admiration (of the onlookers) I truly caused it to be suitable/fitting."[61] Both the quality of being "fitting" and the admiration that that provokes are part of the summary statement of the temple. As with the accounts of Sumerian temples already cited, the statement that a work is for, or provokes, admiration is generally the closing affirmation of the work in the texts.

Paul Garelli has suggested that those palaces and other works that provoke admiration do so through the great effort expended and the precious materials utilised.[62] From a survey of all instances where the construction is used, his criteria can be extended to include a wide variety of properties related to material, skill, and scale,

plus attributes of form and artful manufacture and the presence of what to us seems ineffable, like radiance.[63] But I would argue that the sum of all of the properties is the ability to evoke the **u_6-di/tabrītu** response of intense "ad+miration."

As noted, when the texts specify those who respond to works in this way, they are neither the high gods nor rulers. The case of the Anunna-gods in Gudea's Cylinder B can be understood as hyperbole that reaches beyond the temple's earthly spectators; but since the Anunna-gods are a class of undifferentiated lower divinities, not the named gods of the pantheon, the descriptive terminology is still restricted to the general audience, as distinct from direct beneficiaries of the work. The only instance I have found in which a high god is so engaged is a reference in one of the Shulgi hymns of the Third Dynasty of Ur (late third millennium B.C.E.) to the goddess Inanna, who looks in ad+miration as the king enters her shrine.[64] This latter instance can best be understood if Shulgi's entrance into the shrine is viewed in conjunction with his performance of the "Sacred Marriage" rite, in which the bride Inanna receives her bridegroom; it is then specific to the context of the royal hymn, where the lover (the goddess) may be said to be overwhelmed by the sight of the beloved (the ruler). What is certain is that to date, no responses of the high deities to cultic objects or temples made/built on their behalf have been preserved describing their experience of the works in terms of "wonder," or "ad+miration," **u_6-di** or *tabrītu;* rather, theirs is a response of "joy," or "delight."

I believe the identification of respondents and their differential responses to be a not-trivial distinction. Gods, or kings, constitute the primary recipients of building/work projects. It is with them in mind that the projects have been undertaken; they are in effect the intended beneficiaries of the undertaking, and thus, *active* recipients of the work. Their response is therefore described in terms of direct gratification: joy, pleasure, delight.[65] By contrast, when "the people," or the minor deities like the Annunaki reported by Gudea, stand before a major work, they constitute a more *passive* audience: not the project's direct beneficiaries, but its onlookers. They react to the qualities and overall affect of the particular enterprise as *spectators;* and as such, they are neither proprietary nor directly gratified; they are instead impressed, if not overwhelmed. Both responses – joy/delight and ad+miration – are grounded in the act of seeing; however, for the gods, seeing is the point of departure, the trigger for an emotional response in anticipation of active engagement, whereas for the populace, the end experience *is* the act of seeing itself, intensified as the powerful emotional reaction of admiration.

A less frequently used formula actually articulates a response comprised not only of admiration but also of awe so powerful that it reduces respondents to a state of combined jubilation-cum-speechlessness (Sum. **nig_2-me-gar;** Akk. *qâlu*).[66] In this way do the people respond to the goddess Inanna;[67] but even more interesting is the combination **u_6-di-nig_2-me-gar-sag-gi_6-ga,** "the admiration and awe of the black-headed people (the Sumerians)," in response to the god Enlil.[68]

The two are combined again in a description of the cultic **ma-gur_8**-boat of Shulgi approaching the quay, "a thing of awe, its admiration does not end," **nig_2-**

me-gar-am$_3$ u$_6$-di-bi nu-til$_3$-le.[69] Sjöberg has described **nig$_2$-me-gar** as an unsounded intake of breath. It is an immediate and physiological response to the experience of power, as is clear in the hymn to the Ulmash temple of Inanna, where it is the temple's affect that makes awed silence fall upon (?) enemy lands, **nig$_2$-me-gar ki-bala-a DU$_7$-DU$_7$.**[70] Sjöberg has also commented upon the close connection of **nig$_2$-me-gar** with **u$_6$-di** in the sense of a joined awe or anticipation plus ad+miration.[71] Together they heighten the intensity of the viewer/reactor's response. The entity, god or work, provoking awe and admiration, is then something sufficiently powerful and/or impressive that it is experienced with extremely strong emotion.[72]

I find myself tending to think of the ad+miration/awe responses in terms of a sort of WOW! effect on the people, parallel to, but different from, the joy response of the gods. It is as if the impact of the work when viewed by the people is perceived as impressive, if not overwhelming, whereas when viewed by the gods, their own inherent power matches that of the work, and so their response is seen not in terms of being overwhelmed but rather well met. What to the gods produces delight, to those on a lower level evokes admiration and awe; and therefore, vision must be understood not as an absolute but as a social phenomenon.

When seen in this light, it is further possible to understand the use of the terms **u$_6$-di/***tabrītu* in so many royal texts as part of the ideological apparatus of the state. It is a way, after all, of calling attention to the investment in and the merit to be obtained from a given work or project, by claiming for it a powerful visual affect and/or response.

I would suggest that this is why so many official texts conclude their descriptions of important projects with the summary statement of the work's ability to elicit admiration, or "wonder" – the ultimate affirmation of an enterprise. Thus, the closing passage of Gudea's Cylinder A on the building of the Eninnu moves from description of the affective properties of the temple to an assessment of its impact. And in the same way, the Assyrian building accounts also initially lay the groundwork for closure of the project by declaring the undertaking to have been done to perfection. Only then is the work in question declared to be perceived as intended, with admiration, by future princes, or by the people.

In generalizing for all of Mesopotamian culture over a complex 2000-year period, during which many historical shifts and changes in dominant language occur, I have chosen to focus upon continuities, rather than differences. This seems justified both by demonstrable continuities in cultural patterns and by the fact that the present study constitutes an initial investigation of the phenomenon of visual response. It should be stated, however, that there is not always a perfect correspondence across periods or languages where activities or terms related to intensified visual experience are in evidence. For one thing, it will have been noticed that exhortations to view have been cited from the Akkadian, not the Sumerian, literary corpus. For another, later Neo-Assyrian rulers seem to balance references to temple construction with accounts of palace building, both of which elicit strong visual

responses, whereas to date I have not found references to Sumerian palaces that claim to affect their viewing public in the ways described above. What this difference may signify, if indeed it turns out to be consistent and meaningful, is that the class of affecting works has been expanded over time and/or across the Sumerian-to-Akkadian/Assyrian historical divide. Nevertheless, a sufficiently large number of Sumerian logograms are preserved in the written versions of Akkadian terms, and enough connections can be made with individual elements – such as the temples and cult objects eliciting strong responses, as well as the distinction between divine and popular responses to the works celebrated – that I would not want to posit any less importance accorded to vision in Sumerian, as opposed to Akkadian, tradition. For architecture and objects alike, the association of special properties with enhanced visual response forms an essential part of the account of a work, while parallels in writing and meaning of the primary terms suggest that the completed work was no less "affective" in earlier periods than it was later. Finally, in both languages, Sumerian and Akkadian, we find quite comparable rhetorical strategies on the part of Mesopotamian rulers: in particular, the attribution of the people's positive response of ad+miration and awe as the closing statement and ultimate affirmation of their enterprises.[73]

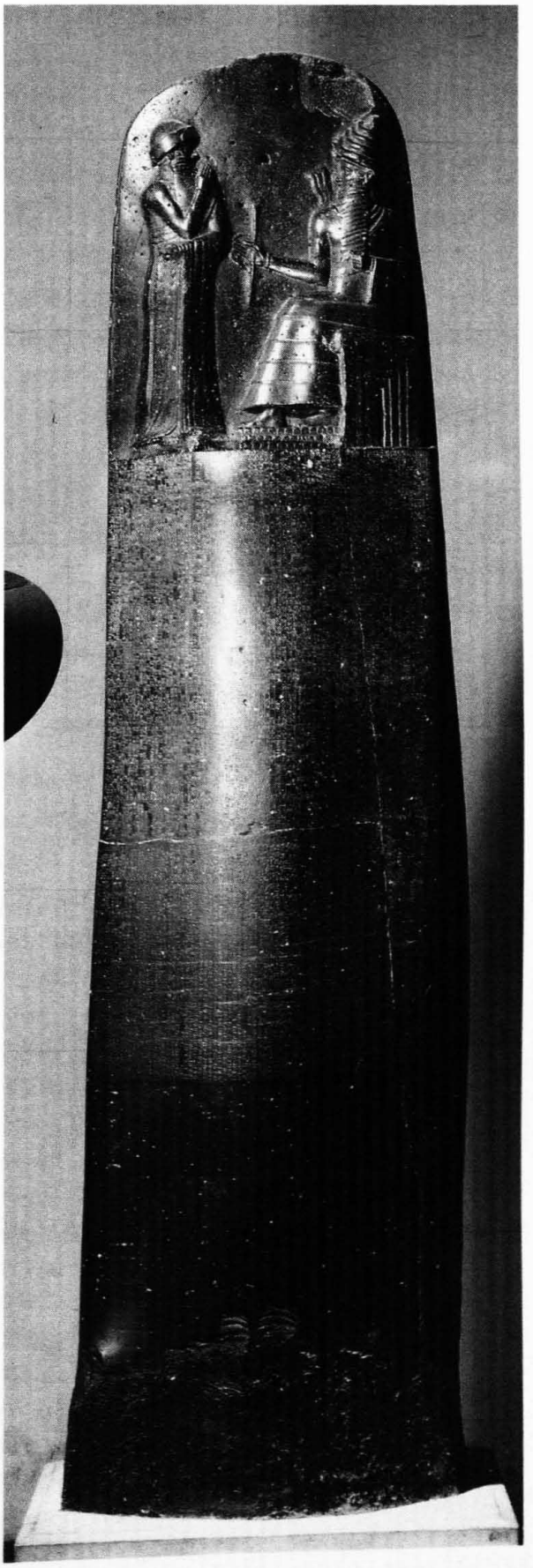
Let us now return to the third millennium Sumerian sculptures with which we began (Figs. 2–4). I would submit that the key to their enlarged eyes does indeed lie in the *votive* nature of the images. But I would add that in addition to the focus of attention, what we are seeing in those eyes is literally the physical manifestation of individuals struck by the **u_6-di** response to the deity before him/her, a deity whose awe-inspiring nature is then reflected in the wide-eyed stare.

In this way, the enlarged eyes of the statues serve both as the expression of devotion and the reflection of the ad+miring response to the awe-inspiring divinity whose image would presumably have been installed in the shrine where the votive statues were placed. Here again, as in the case of the powerfully muscled right arm in the statues of Gudea of Lagash that articulates the divine empowerment of the ruler, form is directly invested with meaning.[74]

That the votive statue, which after all represents the pious devotee, should manifest this visible marker of affect makes sense when it is recalled that deities as well as works are documented as eliciting the identical response resulting from intense visual experience. In fact, if what "the people" are responding to in the works, or at least what is claimed for the works, is the same power as is inherently possessed by the gods, then it should come as no surprise that the responses should be identical. Or, inversely, if for Mesopotamia a primary role played by affective sensory (i.e., aesthetic) experience was to touch and experience (the awesome power inherent in) the divine, then faced directly with the divinity him/herself, one should *expect* the homologous response. Put in the proper hierarchical order, the people respond to the gods with an awe born of the impact derived from direct and intense visual experience of the sacred; and what they respond to in the work – temple, object, or even royal abode – is precisely those properties that link it to the divine.[75]

Nor should this preclude finding enlarged eyes associated with divine images in the Mesopotamian repertoire, despite the notable scarcity of divine images in the archaeological record.[76] Not only are the gods consistently described as "seeing" or "viewing" the objects of their pleasure, as documented in this chapter, but they are also described as viewing the pious in interactions. Thus, in a text of Assurbanipal, the king records that the gods Assur and Ninlil "lift their auspicious eyes," and "look joyfully upon the king," *ina nīš ī[nī]šunu damqāti . . . ḫadīš [it]taplasu,*[77] just as, in Christian worship, the Virgin is invoked by the pious worshiper in the "Salve Regina": "turn thy compassionate eyes toward us," *illos tuos misericordes occulos ad nos converte.*

In the visual record, this relationship is best preserved in narrative relief, where we see kings standing in ritual service before a deity (e.g., the Stele of Ur-Namma of Ur), or in direct audience with the god (as on the Stele of Hammurabi, Fig. 6). In both cases, one Sumerian, the other Old Babylonian, the reciprocity of visual exchange is clearly marked. That the god's "viewing" has implications beyond mere sight toward positive acknowledgment and benevolence is clear from an Old Babylonian hymn to the goddess Ishtar, where she is exalted: *naplasuša bani bu'āru,* "prosperity is created by her gaze."[78] In the end, it is this prosperity *(bu'āru)* in Akkadian, abundance **(ḫe$_2$.gal$_2$)** in Sumerian, that is the ultimate gift of the gods, and thus, to have represented Hammurabi in the same period literally eye to eye with the sun-



6. Stele bearing the Laws of Hammurabi, found at Susa. Old Babylonian Period, 1792–1750 B.C.E. (Photo M. Chuzeville, courtesy Département des antiquités orientales, Musée du Louvre, Paris)

god Shamash is tantamount to proclaiming to viewers of the stele that the king is truly in the god's favor, that his authority to propound the laws also contained on the stele derives directly from the deity, who, if order is properly maintained, will look well *(sic)* upon not only the king, but the kingdom.[79]

The consequence of putting the textual material together with the sculptures has been to make clear how much stress was placed upon vision and visuality within Mesopotamian tradition, and how well vision was understood as a cognitive and symbolic act. In the sculpture, eyes are emphasized, even disproportionally in some periods, and this would seem to signal not only the intensity of the visual bond between, say, devotee and deity but also the augmented visual experience that results. In the texts, gods and rulers *see* not only each other but also works – temples, cult appurtenances, royal images, devotees – and they are pleased: Their hearts rejoice, their faces shine; and the hoped-for result is that they will respond benevolently to the patron/ruler responsible for the work in question, or to the pious supplicant. The generic "people" and the lower-level gods also *see* works – temples, palaces, statuary, luxury goods – and are declared to respond appropriately: with the admiration and awe that results from a powerful visual experience, the bowled-over *spectator* before the *spectacular.* In addition, individuals cathect visually to individual objects: the lover to the beloved, Gilgamesh to his dream-axe. In turn, objects and public works are declared worthy of *being seen,* as a way to underscore their value. In short, as has been argued for classical Greece and the antique in general,[80] so also for ancient Mesopotamia: The act of viewing arouses the spectator's responses. Visuality is coded as affective and powerful, and vision is explicitly acknowledged as the primary path to both religious and aesthetic experience.

NOTES

1 See, for example, Helen Gardner, *Art Through the Ages,* 6th ed. (New York: Harcourt, Brace, Jovanovich, 1975), 51–2 and Figs. 2–10 to 2–12 and 2–18: "One notices at once . . . how disproportionately large the eyes are. . . . The reason for this is convention." "The purpose of these votive figures was to offer constant prayers to the gods in behalf of their donors, and thus their open-eyed stare may symbolize the eternal wakefulness necessary if they are to fulfill their duty."

2 I. J. Winter, "'Idols of the King': Consecrated images of rulers in ancient Mesopotamia," *Journal of Ritual Studies* 6 (1992): 13–42.

3 The two largest images in the Diyala group, one male holding a cup, the other female, have been considered by some scholars to be deities – due to their scale, and an argument that the divine emblem on the base of the male figure precludes his having been an ordinary votary – although my own opinion is that the rest of their attributes and properties place them in the votive category (see partial discussion in A. Spycket, *La Statuaire du Proche-Orient ancien* [Handbuch der Orientalistik, Abt. 7, Bd. 1]) (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1981), 54, and in I. J. Winter, "Review of Spycket, *La Statuaire,*" *Journal of Cuneiform Studies* 36 (1984): 106.

4 For the "eye-stones," see Stephen Langdon, "The Eyes of Ningal," *Revue Assyriologique* 20 (1923): 9–11; Wilfred G. Lambert, "An Eye-stone of Esarhaddon's Queen and Other Similar Gems," *Revue d'Assyriologie* 63 (1969): 65–71; idem., "An Eyestone of Ibbi-Sin," *Iraq* 41 (1979): 44; B. K. Ismail, "Onyx Bead with Sumerian Votive Inscription of Adad-apla-iddina," *Sumer* 37 (1981): 114–15; and recent discussion in F. Tallon, ed., *Les pierres précieuses de l'Orient ancien* (Paris: Réunion des Musées Nationaux, 1995), 72–3 re object No. 105. There are nearly 30 such eye-stones known, from the late Neo-Sumerian period in the end of the third millennium B.C.E. to the Neo-Babylonian period in the middle of the first. The brownish color of the agate with its white center closely resembles a human eye. One of the most complete dedicatory inscriptions reads: "To Baba, her mistress, for the life of Ibbi-Sin [the last ruler of the Ur III period], Aman-ili, lady of Ir-nanna, governor of Lagash, dedicated (this object)" (Lambert, *Iraq* 41: 44).

5 Discussed in Winter, *Journal of Ritual Studies* 6: 21.

6 *The Epic of Gilgamesh,* trans. Maureen G. Kovacs (Stanford, Calif.: Stanford University Press, 1985), 3, Tablet I, l. 12.

7 Euripides, *Ion,* trans. W. S. Di Piero, with Introduction by Peter Burian [The Greek Tragedy in New Translations] (New York and Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996), ll. 164–225: Chorus: "Look! Images of the gods housed here. . . . Look at this! Herakles, son of Zeus." See also on this the study by Froma I. Zeitlin, "The Artful Eye: Vision, Ecphrasis and Spectacle in Euripidean Theatre," in Simon Goldhill and Robin Osborne, eds., *Art and Text in Ancient Greek Culture* [Cambridge Studies in New Art History and Criticism] (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 138–96, in particular the discussion, 145, of 'hyperviewing': "those moments . . . [that] join word and image in pictorial language."

8 Zeitlin, op. cit., 148. See also, her discussion, 157 and n. 50, of *Iphigenia in Aulis,* l. 190–1, 203–5, and 232–4, where, like the *Ion,* the act of looking carries with it an emphasis on the emotive and aesthetic aspects of the experience: the desire to see (190–1), the joy taken in sating one's eyes with a visual spectacle (232–4), the particular aesthetic stimuli that arouse an astonished gaze (203, 205).

9 See, for example, Charles Segal, "Cold Delight: Art, Death and the Transgression of Genre," in *Euripides and the Poetics of Sorrow* (Durham, N.C., and London: Duke University Press, 1993), 37–50.

10 Raymond A. Prier, *Thauma Idesthai: The Phenomenology of Sight and Appearance in Archaic Greek* (Tallahassee, Fla.: The Florida State University Press, 1989).

11 Benjamin Foster, "Gilgamesh: Sex, Love and the Ascent of Knowledge," in John H. Marks and Robert M. Good, eds., *Love and Death in the Ancient Near East* (Guilford, Conn.: Four Quarters Publishing Co., 1987), 27 (= Gilg. OB Pa i 31–6, esp. l. 32–3).

12 Recognition that sight is vested in the human species – indeed, in all animate species – is, of course, self-evident. The extent to which responses to *particular* visual stimuli similarly reside in the neurophysiology of the species have yet to be determined. Some recent studies have begun to investigate these questions, dealing with both hard-wiring responses to certain patterns, forms, and compositions, *and* the emotional responses (like awe) that ensue (see, for example, Jeremy Dronfield, "Entering Alternative Realities: Cognition, Art and Architecture in Irish Passage-Tombs," *Cambridge Archaeological Journal 6:1* [1996]: 37–72). Nevertheless, precisely *because* sight is common to the species, it is the individual cultural adaptations and attendant valuations that are interesting. As with many cultural patterns, it is important to gather cross-cultural data

before one can begin to discuss whether similarities are the product of historical interaction, independent invention within a range of possibilities, or "universals" explainable through reference to the neurophysiology of the species.

13 See the bilingual tablet from Nineveh, B. Landsberger and O. R. Gurney, "**igi-duḫ-a** = *tāmartu*, short version," *Archiv für Orientforschung* 18 (1957): 81–6, for Sumerian and Akkadian equivalents. The Akkadian terms are discussed in the relevant entries in the *Chicago Assyrian Dictionary*, henceforth *CAD*, and in W. von Soden, *Akkadisches Handwörterbuch* (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1972), henceforth *AHw*. For the Sumerian, to date, most publication series have had to include their own glossaries, but see also brief definitions in M. L. Thomsen, *Sumerian Language: An Introduction to Its History and Grammatical Structure* (Copehagen: Akademisk Forlag, 1984), as well as the volumes of the fledgling *Philadelphia Sumerian Dictionary*, A 1 and 2 and B. (Note that Sumerian words are generally rendered in **bold;** Akkadian in *italics* or *underlined*.)

14 *CAD* N1: 306, *naplasu*, "to look, glance."

15 Gilg. Nineveh I v 15. Kovacs, *Gilgamesh*, 10 renders the same line: "Look at him, gaze at his face."

16 Nineveh I v 16–18. Kovacs, *Gilgamesh*, 10: "He is a handsome youth, with freshness (?), his entire body exudes voluptuousness."

17 I. J. Winter, "Sex, Rhetoric, and the Public Monument: The Alluring Body of Naram-Sîn of Agade," in Natalie B. Kampen, ed., *Sexuality in Ancient Art* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 11–26, esp. 18–19. Note also that on the whole monument, all eyes are on the ruler – both the soldiers that follow him over ascending terrain and the enemy whose necks bend at increasing angles the farther they are down the right-hand margin, in order to keep the victorious Naram-Sîn in their line of vision.

18 Gilg. P. ii 11, cited in *CAD* N2: 122, *naṭālu;* see also, discussion in Foster, "Gilgamesh," 21–42.

19 Bendt Alster, "Sumerian Love Songs," *Revue d'Assyriologie* 79 (1985): 143–4 (= SRT 31: 4).

20 See Amarna Letter, EA 151: 18, cited *CAD* D: 21, *daǧālu*, and an Old Babylonian bilingual of the reign of Samsuiluna (ca. 1749–1712 B.C.E.), the Sumerian version reading: **igi.zalag.ga.ne.ne.a hu.mu.ši.in.bar.re.eš** – cited *CAD* B: 320, *būnu* A.

21 Bilingual text of Nebuchadnezzar I of Babylon (1124–1103 B.C.E.), referring to an image of the god Marduk, cited *CAD* B: 115, *barû*, and published most recently by Grant Frame, *Rulers of Babylonia from the Second Dynasty of Isin to the End of Assyrian Domination* [*Royal Inscriptions of Mesopotamia: Babylonian Periods*, vol. 2 (henceforth, *RIMB* 2)] (Toronto: The University of Toronto Press, 1995), 30 (= Neb I. B.2.4.9, lines 15–16). The Sumerian **un.ma.da igi.kar$_2$.kar$_2$.ra.ab e$_2$.gar$_8$.bi sukud.da** duplicates the verb, as **igi.kar$_2$.kar$_2$,** but this could be either a function of intensification or of response to the plurality implied in the people of the land, **un.ma.da.** The Akkadian is clear, however: The verb *barû* is conjugated in a form that provides the same intensification of the simple verb for seeing as "to smash" would be for the simple verb "to break."

22 A. Kirk Grayson, *Royal Inscriptions of Mesopotamia: Assyrian Period*, vol. 1 [henceforth, *RIMA* 1] (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1987), 185 (= Shalm. I.1.148–51).

23 For example, R. Borger, *Die Inschriften Asarhaddons, Königs von Assyrien* [henceforth *Es.*] [AfO Beiheft 9] (Osnabrück: Biblio Verlag, 1967), ¶20, Borsippa A 20, regarding the temple of the goddess Gula in Borsippa, also now published in Frame, *RIMB* 2, 74 (= *Es.* B.6.31.10, l. 20). The text relates that the king restored its ruins, then closes: "[M]ay [Gula] look upon this work joyously" (i.e., with pleasure), *[šip]ru(?) šuāti ḫadīš*

lippa[lisma]. Indeed, this formulation is typical of all of Esarhaddon's temple building and restoration in Babylon: See, for example, Frame, op. cit., 177, temple for the goddess Queen-of-Nippur; 179, for the god Enlil; 184, for the goddess Ishtar. This was apparently formulaic, as it is used in Babylon by local rulers as well as by Assyrians: e.g., Marduk-apla-iddina II (Merodach-Baladan II, 721–710 B.C.E.), who requests of the goddess Ishtar that when she "looks joyously upon" the work he has done, she may bestow a long life upon the king, in Frame, *RIMB* 2, 138 (= B.6.21.a, l. 30–1).

24 Borger, *Es.* 5–6 = ¶2, Assur A vii 18–20.

25 A. Kirk Grayson, *The Royal Inscriptions of Mesopotamia: Assyrian Period*, vol. 2 [henceforth, *RIMA* 2] (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1991), 296 = ANP II.32.10–11; Northwest Palace = *RIMA* 2, 301–2 (= ANP II.35.8).

26 *RIMA* 2, 297 (= ANP II.32.15–18).

27 *RIMA* 2, 302 (= ANP II.35.9–10): *ussimši ušarriḫši umami KUR-e u A.AB.BA.MEŠ DU_3-šunu ša NA_4 puli BABBAR-e u NA_4 parūte DU_3 ina KA_2.MEŠ-ša ušziz.*

28 Cited *CAD* D: 22, *dagālu* (= VAB 4 118 ii 53).

29 Cited *CAD* B: 320, *būnu* (= VAB 4 258 ii 21).

30 W. von Soden, "Zwei Königsgebete an Ištar aus Assyrien," *Archiv für Orientforschung* 25 (1974–7): 37–49; cited also *CAD* N2: 124, *naṭalu*.

31 Cited *CAD* N2: 128, *naṭalu* (= PBS 15 79 i 40 and duplicate CT 37 8 i 39 [Nbk]).

32 Cited *CAD* B: 318, *bunnanû*, from the Kurba'il text of Shalmaneser III, originally published J. V. Kinnier-Wilson, "The Kurba'il Statue of Shalmaneser III," *Iraq* 24: 94, l. 37–8.

33 Borger, *Es.*, 77 (= ¶50, Uruk D 14–18).

34 Borger, *Es.*, 32 and Frame, *RIMB* 2, 177 (= ¶20, Borsippa A 20), cited in n. 21.

35 Cited *CAD* H: 23, *ḫadīš* (= Streck ABP.240.15).

36 Grayson, *RIMA* 1, 185 (= Shalmaneser I.1.148–51).

37 Borger, *Es.*, 75–6 (= ¶48, Uruk B) and Frame, *RIMB* 2, 189, l. 18–20, concerning the restoration of the Ehiliana, the cella of the goddess Nanaia at Uruk.

38 Borger, *Es.*, 76 and Frame, *RIMB* 2, 187, l. 16–19.

39 Douglas Frayne, *Royal Inscriptions of Mesopotamia, Early Periods*, vol. 4 [henceforth, *RIME* 4] (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1991), 303 (= Rim-Sin I.23.27–9).

40 See Hermann Behrens and Horst Steible, *Glossar zu dem altsumerischen Bau- und Weihinschriften* [Freiburger altorientalische Studien 6] (Wiesbaden: Steiner Verlag, 1983), 349, citing MSL XIII 168, 14′-16′.

41 Thorkild Jacobsen, "Lugalbanda and Ninsuna," *JCS* 41 (1989): 78 re **u_6-dug$_4$** = *hâtu*, and its imperfective, **u_6-e/di.** Jacobsen reads Enmerkar 63: "may the people look at me admiringly," **[nam]-lu_2-lu_6 u_6 du_{10}-ge-eš ḫu-mu-un-e,** and the bilingual text 4R 28 2:7, "you looked not at your house," **e_2-zu u_6 li-bi$_2$-du$_3$** = *bītka ul tamur*, where the Akkadian, from the verb *amāru*, "to see," is very clear.

42 Prier, *Thauma Idesthai*, especially 81–97.

43 Royal hymn of the Isin period, cited by Françoise Bruschweiler, *Inanna: La déesse triomphante et vaincue dans la cosmologie sumérienne* (Geneva: Université de Genève, 1987), 33, 117, 120.

44 Jacob Klein, *Three Šulgi Hymns* (Ramat Gan: Bar Ilan University Press, 1981), 72 (= Shulgi D.7).

45 Ibid., 72 (= Shulgi D.33).

46 Ake W. Sjöberg, *Sumerian Temple Hymns* (Locust Valley, N.Y.: Augustin, 1969), 30 (= TH 17:217), on the temple of Dumuzi in Badtibira.

47 Ibid., 29 (= TH 16: 199), translated by Sjöberg as "marvelous."

48 Ibid., 40 (= TH 31:397).

49 Jacob Klein, "Building and Dedication Hymns in Sumerian Literature," *Acta Sumerologica* 11 (1989): 48, 51 (= Ur-N B.21). Klein renders the same line: "He displayed it for wonder among the multitudes of the people."

50 Gudea Cyl. A 24: 17 and 24: 25; see the text edition in D. O. Edzard, *Gudea and his Dynasty* [*Royal Inscriptions of Mesopotamia, Early Periods*, vol. 3/1] (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1997, 84). A translation of the complete cylinder also appears in Thorkild Jacobsen, *The Harps that Once: Sumerian Poetry in Translation* (New Haven, Conn., & London: Yale University Press, 1987), 386–425 (this line = 419).

51 Cyl. B 1: 11; Edzard, *RIME* 3/1, 89 and Jacobsen, *Harps*, 426 for this line.

52 Cited *Pennsylvania Sumerian Dictionary* (henceforth *PSD*) AI: 163, **a-sal-bar** (= Lamentation over Sumer and Ur 426). See also P. Michalowski, *The Lamentation over the Destruction of Sumer and Ur* (Winona Lake, Ind.: Eisenbraun's, 1989), 62–3, who renders the line rather differently, but retains the sense of the visual through his use of "admired" and "admiration" in English: "The admired temple that used (to receive) first class oil, its admiration was extinguished."

53 Frayne, *RIME* 4, 158 (= Sin-iddinam 1.36–7).

54 Ibid., 303 (= Rim Sin 23: 23–9).

55 H. Steible, *Die neusumerischen Bau- und Weihinschriften*, Freiburger altorientalische Studien 9 (Stuttgart: Steiner Verlag, 1991), Ibbi Su'en 9: 17–28.

56 Klein, *Acta Sumerologica* 11, 37–41 (= Išmedagan I.9–10).

57 See von Soden, *AHw*, 1299: *tabrītu*.

58 See discussion in P. Garelli, "La Conception de la beauté en Assyrie," in Tzvi Abusch et al., eds., *Lingering Over Words: Studies in Ancient Near Eastern Literature in Honor of William L. Moran* (Atlanta, Ga.: The Scholar's Press, 1990), 175.

59 Borger, *Es.*, 72 (= ¶43, Tarbisu A 43 30). Esarhaddon adds a variation as well, in his account of the stele he set up in Sam'al, a province to the west. On the stele itself he declares that it was set up *ana tabrât kiššat nakirī*, for the wondering gaze of all enemies!

60 See n. 28.

61 Cited *CAD* A2: 329, *asāmu* in the causative Š-stem, *šūsumu* (= VAB 4 64 iii 30), "to make fitting."

62 Garelli, "La Conception de la beauté," in Abusch et al., eds., *Lingering Over Words*, 175–6.

63 This will be developed further in a study under preparation.

64 See Klein, *Three Shulgi Hymns*, 136 (= Šulgi X.11).

65 The one exception to this with which I am familiar is a royal statement that Esarhaddon's workmen respond to the completion of their task in building the royal palace with joy and jubilation. Here, however, it could be said that the rhetorical nature of the text has governed the report as a self-reflexive statement of celebration.

66 *CAD* Q: 72, *qâlu* A, "to become silent, to stay quiet; to pay attention (with the sense of a focus of attention)." The bilingual equivalent is found in Irving L. Finkel, *The Series SIG.ALAN* = Nabnītu [*Materials for the Sumerian Lexicon* 16] (Rome: Pontificium Institutum Biblicum, 1982), Tablet III.168–73 and IV.232: **nig$_2$-me-gar** = *qâlum*, *nīšātum*, resp.

67 See Bruschweiler, *Inanna*, 117, citing the text "The Exaltation of Inanna," **nin-me-šar$_2$-ra**, l. 21–2. This text has been reedited by Annette Zgoll, *Der Rechtsfall der Enhedu-Ana im Lied* ***nin-me-šara*** [Alter Orient und Altes Testament 246] (Münster: Ugarit-Verlag, 1997).

68 From the text known as "Enlil in the Ekur," l. 129 – the text edition made available to me by the editors from the files of the *PSD*, gratefully acknowledged.

69 From the text known as "Inanna & Bilulu," 4 rev. I: 14 – see S. Langdon, *Historical and Religious texts . . . Nippur* [*Babylonian Expedition of the University of Pennsylvania*, Series A, vol. 31] (Munich, 1914).

70 Sjöberg, *Sumerian Temple Hymns*, 47 (= TH 40: 510).

71 Ibid., 144, discussion to Temple Hymn 40.

72 I have, in fact, been present at a moment of such collective response, in the early-morning opening *(darşan)* of the shrine of the ruby image of Siva Natarāja in the temple of Cidambaram in South India. As is well known in Hindu tradition, the reciprocal viewing of deity and devotee constitutes an important aspect of worship – on which, see Diana Eck, *Darśan: Seeing the Divine Image in India*, 2d ed. (Chambersburg, Pa: Anima, 1985). At Cidambaram, in the period before the god was to be on view, an increasingly anticipatory silence pervaded the assembled devotees, and then, at the moment when the shrine was opened, literally everyone simultaneously *drew in a deep breath as he/she experienced the powerful visual impact of the god's presence*. That something similar was intended in the Mesopotamian context is strongly suggested by a Babylonian text that refers to "seeing the god's face" as a euphemism for the cultic manifestation of the deity through his image: *aššum muppalsāta ātamar pānika*, on which, see W. Mayer, *Untersuchungen zur Formensprache der babylonischen 'Gebetsbeschwörungen'* [Studia Pohl, Series Maior 5] (Rome, 1976), 478–81, re l. 15–18.

73 Anticipated for the future would be chronological studies of the variations in terms and usage over time (and studies of variation across space!), along with a careful and systematic study of these terms in direct relation to the actual works preserved to us, to see precisely *how* the attributes claimed in textual sources may have been manifest visually as "style" in any given period.

74 On this issue, as manifest in Mesopotamian art, see I. J. Winter, "The Affective Properties of Styles: An Inquiry into Analytical Process and the Inscription of Meaning in Art History," in C. A. Jones and P. Galison, eds., *Picturing Science, Producing Art* (New York & London: Routledge, 1998), 55–77.

75 An interesting aspect of this point that cannot be developed in the present context is the distinction between the role of vision in Mesopotamian tradition and the role of "hearing" as the means of experiencing the divine in the Hebrew Bible. Stephen A. Geller has pursued the history of the two senses as vehicles for the transmission of divine will in "Fiery Wisdom: Logos and Lexis in Deuteronomy 4," *Prooftexts* 14 (1994): 103–39, where he sees a definite development from an originally privileged role for sight, which then over time gave way to an ultimate privileging of the sense of hearing God's "word" – see esp. 122–4, 134, and 139, n. 24. The contrast is extremely instructive for apprehending just what was entailed in the Mesopotamian visual experience. The issue is also discussed by David Chidester, *Word and Light: Seeing, Hearing, and Religious Discourse* (Urbana, Ill.: University of Illinois Press, 1992) – for which reference I am indebted to Robert Nelson.

76 Spycket, *La statuaire*, 77, 144, 185, 203. Only a sample of divine statues will permit us to assess whether gods' eyes are as enlarged as those of votive statues, however.

77 Cited in *CAD* B: 320, *būnu* A (= Asb). Note that the verb form derives from the verbs *palāsu, naplusu*, the same verbs that appear frequently in association with cathected viewing. That this phraseology has a long history in Babylonian texts can be demonstrated: See, for example, the text of Nebuchadnezzer I of the twelfth century B.C.E.,

in Frame, *RIMB* 2, 32 (= Neb I B.2.4.10, l. 12), noting that the Sungod "looked joyously (upon him)" and gave him the kingship of all people.

78 Cited *CAD* N1: 306, *naplusu* (= RA 22 170: 15).

79 See now on the relationship between god and king on the Law stele of Hammurabi, I. J. Winter, "Art in Empire: The Royal Image and the Visual Dimensions of Assyrian Ideology," in S. Parpola and R. M. Whiting, eds., *Assyria 1995* (Helsinki: University of Helsinki Press, 1997), 366–7.

80 For Greece, Prier, *Thauma Idesthai*, passim, and Zeitlin, "The Artful Eye . . .", 141–2. Zeitlin also cites R. Padel, "Making Space Speak," in R. Winkler and F. I. Zeitlin, eds., *Nothing to Do with Dionysos? Athenian Drama in its Social Context* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1990) and D. Seale, *Vision and Stagecraft in Sophocles* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1982). For the antique in general, J. Elsner, "Image and Ritual: Reflections on the Religious Appreciation of Classical Art," *The Classical Quarterly* 46, no. 2 (1996): esp. 522; and K. Pomian, "Vision and Cognition," in C. A. Jones and P. Galison, eds., *Picturing Science, Producing Art*, 211–13.

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Seeing as Others Saw

Edited by
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